

Work Motivation

Self-Determination Theory (SDT)

Why people do what they do at work — and how to create the conditions in which they motivate themselves. The difference between “I have to” and “I want to,” and the ABC of needs that powers high-quality motivation.

Built on the work of **Edward Deci** & **Richard Ryan**, with Van den Broeck, Van Coillie, Forest & Müller

Chapter 2 | Why SDT · Theory X/Y · Types of Motivation · The ABC of Needs · Motivating Leadership

A structured companion to the Chapter 2 material. It keeps the full content of the source but reorganises it for study — adding the core SDT diagrams (the motivation continuum, the ABC triad, the motivation-profile grid), consequence tables, worked examples, a glossary and self-test questions.

What this chapter covers

Chapter 1 asked whether we *choose* well. Chapter 2 asks a different question: once someone is *in* a role, what actually makes them act — and how do you get high-quality, lasting motivation rather than the fragile kind? Self-Determination Theory (SDT) is the most thoroughly tested modern answer.

0. Why motivate according to SDT?

Without motivation there is no behaviour · Why SDT · Four myths it dismantles

1. The metatheory: Theory X vs. Theory Y

Two views of people · Why your assumptions become self-fulfilling · “You get what you think”

2. Types of motivation: “I have to” vs. “I want to”

Amotivation · Intrinsic & extrinsic · The crowding-out experiment · The motivation continuum
Controlled vs. autonomous · Consequences (meta-analysis) · Motivation profiles · Job vs. task

3. The ABC of motivation: the three basic needs

Autonomy · Belongingness · Competence · Autonomy ≠ independence · 7 characteristics · Consequences

4. Putting it to work: motivating leadership

Four leadership styles · ABC-supportive vs. controlling leadership · Structure · Trust & psychological safety
· The ABC language · Change & remote work

5. Glossary & self-test

THE ONE-SENTENCE VERSION

People are motivated in different *ways*, and the way matters more than the amount: **autonomous** motivation (“I want to” — because it's enjoyable or meaningful) drives well-being and performance, while **controlled** motivation (“I have to” — outer or inner pressure) does not. You produce autonomous motivation by satisfying three basic needs — **A**utonomy, **B**elongingness, **C**ompetence.

0. Why motivate according to SDT?

Without motivation, there is no behaviour

The word *motivation* comes from the Latin *movere* — “to move.” Motivation is the **energy** that (1) makes you choose one task over another, (2) sets you in motion, and (3) makes you persevere when things get hard. Without it there is no movement: it is the basis of everything we do. It's what gets the marketing campaign finished, keeps the author writing when it's difficult — or, when misdirected, has you doodling on your phone instead of following the meeting. Something is always driving your behaviour. The practical question is not *whether* people are motivated, but **how**.

Why base a whole book on SDT?

- **It is one of the most influential, best-tested motivation theories.** Founded by Edward Deci in the 1970s (experiments on how rewards affect intrinsic motivation) and developed with Richard Ryan into a broad theory backed by thousands of studies.
- **It is universal.** The same principles work at work, at home, in the gym and the classroom — across cultures, East and West.
- **It is broad and practical.** It explains *why* we act, *for whom* it works, and *how* to strengthen high-quality motivation — and it pays: research suggests every €1 invested in SDT-based motivation returns more than €3 within 12 months (less burnout, more productivity, innovation, involvement, lower absence).

“SDT is one of the most influential theories of motivation in the 21st century and represents our current understanding of how to facilitate and sustain high quality motivation.”

— Edward Deci & Richard Ryan

Four myths SDT dismantles

The myth	What SDT says instead
A • “Some people just can't be motivated.”	Everyone is motivated — even your most difficult colleague. You can't force quality motivation with money, control or threats, but you <i>can</i> create the right environment in which people motivate themselves (so you don't have to police them).
B • “Intrinsic motivation is the only good kind.”	Not so. Much of work isn't fun, yet people can be excellently motivated for dull tasks <i>if those tasks are made meaningful</i> . Meaning can be as powerful as enjoyment.
C • “The more motivation, the better.”	No — <i>type</i> beats amount. Acting out of fear or guilt is motivation too, but low-quality. More pressure-based motivation is not better.
D • “Motivating people is hard and complex.”	SDT gives a simple working handle: people are optimally motivated when they experience A utonomy, B elongingness and C ompetence.

“Instead of asking ‘how can I motivate people’, we should be asking ‘how can I create the conditions within which people will motivate themselves’.”

— Edward Deci

1. The metatheory: what you think is what you get

Before any technique, SDT asks about your underlying *view of people*. McGregor (1960) framed the two poles as Theory X and Theory Y. Which one you hold quietly shapes how you manage — and, through that, how motivated your people actually become.

Two views of people (McGregor, 1960)

Theory X — pessimistic	Theory Y — optimistic
People are passive, lazy, not naturally motivated for work; they'd rather languish.	People are active, growth-oriented, curious; they want to develop and learn.
They need pressure and control; they can't really be trusted (they'll slack off given the chance).	They are proactive and shape their environment; they can be trusted and given space.
They come to work only for the paycheck. Motivate with rewards and threats — the carrot and the stick.	They care about the organisation and chose it. Collaboration is built on trust; mistakes are growth opportunities.
Echoed by Agency Theory (agents can't be trusted with principals' interests).	The starting point of SDT.

Why the choice is self-fulfilling

Science can't prove which view is “true” — but it shows the two produce **different realities**. Believe people are lazy, and you'll give orders, monitor closely, and reward/punish; people then wait passively for instructions, because taking initiative in a direction you didn't sanction only risks punishment. Believe people are active, and you'll give space, treat mistakes as learning, and invite ideas; people then bring initiative and often achieve great things. In each case the belief creates the behaviour that confirms it. **What you think is what you get.**

“If I kick my dog, he will move. And when I want him to move again, what must I do? I must kick him again. But it is only when he has his own generator that we can talk about motivation. He then needs no outside stimulation. He wants to do it.”

— Frederick Herzberg

SDT STARTS FROM THEORY Y

People are inherently active and growth-oriented (yes, we all enjoy a lazy Sunday — but the tendency to grow is there and can be tapped). Firms like **Zappos** (personalised workspaces, hiring “fun and a little weird” people), **Netflix** (unlimited vacation tied to meeting goals) and **Google** (“20% time”) lean on Theory Y to unlock initiative. Theory-X details creep in everywhere too — a time-clock that fires a punctual, productive worker for carpool lateness signals distrust louder than any mission statement.

2. Types of motivation: “I have to” vs. “I want to”

SDT's signature insight: people can be motivated for the very same job for entirely different *reasons*, and those reasons lead to different consequences. The reasons form a continuum from no motivation, through pressured motivation, to willing motivation.

First split: motivated or not?

The baseline distinction is between **amotivation** and being motivated. Amotivated employees feel helpless — they sense that acting is futile because the outcome won't come anyway. They show up, but float through the day counting hours. SDT's reassuring finding is that *most* employees are motivated in some way; the work is in improving the *quality* of that motivation.

Second split: intrinsic vs. extrinsic — and why rewards can backfire

Intrinsic motivation = doing the work for its own sake, because it's fun or interesting (you'd keep doing it after winning the lottery). **Extrinsic motivation** = doing it for something in return (pay, a company car, a pat on the back). Classical theory says: to get more effort, add rewards. SDT's founding experiment showed that this can *destroy* the motivation you started with.

FOUNDING EXPERIMENT · THE PUZZLE STUDY (DECI, 1971)

TASK Students solved intrinsically interesting puzzles across three lab sessions. Midway through each, the experimenter left; “free time” could be spent on the puzzles or on magazines. *Time spent on puzzles during the free break = the measure of intrinsic motivation.*

CONTROL GROUP Never paid, all three sessions.

EXPERIMENTAL GROUP Session 1: unpaid. Session 2: paid \$1 per puzzle. Session 3: told the money ran out — unpaid again.

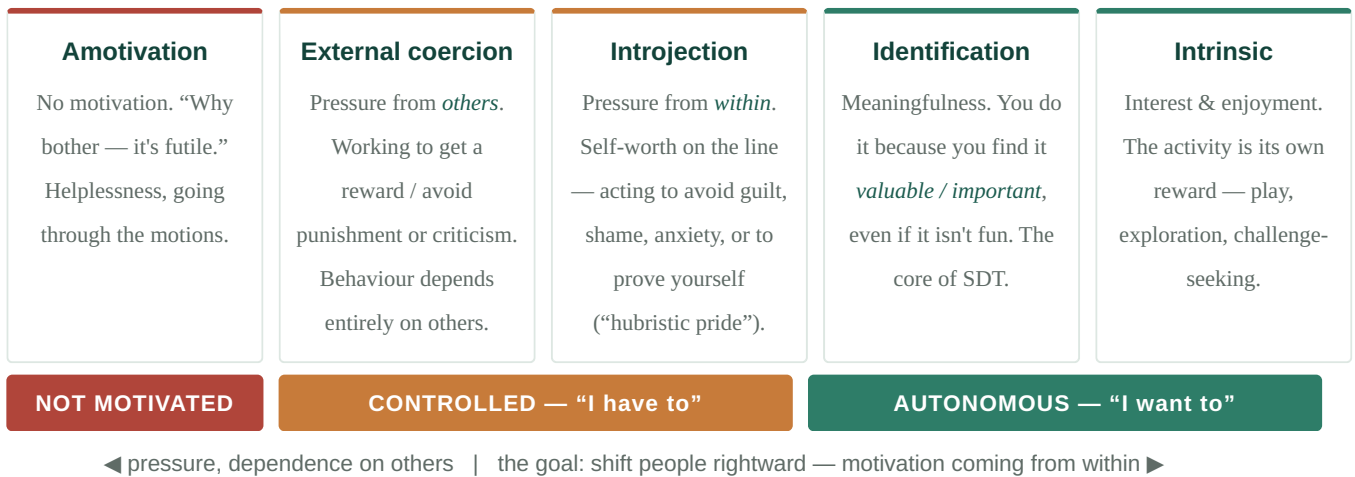
Result: in session 2 the paid group worked harder (intrinsic + extrinsic motivation stacked). But in session 3 — reward gone — they spent **markedly less** free time on the puzzles than in session 1, and less than the never-paid control group. Introducing and then removing a reward left them *less* intrinsically motivated than if they'd never been paid at all.

This is the crowding-out effect: an external reward can undermine intrinsic motivation. Replicated many times, with money and with praise. You may have felt it — loving reading until school made you write book reports; losing creative joy once clients started judging your hobby-turned-job.

This poses a real problem: we *all* get paid. Does a salary erase intrinsic motivation? Not necessarily — because, SDT discovered, **not all extrinsic motivation is the same**.

The full picture: four types of motivation on a continuum

SDT breaks extrinsic motivation into three kinds and places all four motivations on a single quality continuum:



The three extrinsic types, in detail

- **A • External coercion** — you let your behaviour depend on others' judgement: to get job security, a bonus, a promotion, more praise or less criticism. Highly controlling. *“Coercion can only end in chaos.” — Gandhi.*
- **B • Introjection (internal coercion)** — the “must” has been swallowed and now comes from inside. Self-esteem, ego and status ride on performance; you act to avoid feeling guilty, ashamed or “like a failure.” Even acting to “be proud of yourself” or to boast about a title counts — this is *hubristic* pride (self-worth at stake), the opposite of *authentic* pride (proud of a job well done, able to shrug off failure with “I’ll do better next time”).
- **C • Identification (meaningfulness)** — you're committed because the work is valuable and important to you. Construction workers “building a home for their customers”; nurses for whom caring is part of who they are. It's still extrinsic — finding something *important* isn't the same as *enjoying* it — but it carries you through the unpleasant parts *because* you see their value.

Plus the fourth, non-extrinsic type — **intrinsic motivation**, where the reward is the activity itself.

THE KEY REFRAME — CONTROLLED VS. AUTONOMOUS

The old dividing line (extrinsic vs. intrinsic) is *not* the important one. The important line runs **through** the extrinsic types:

- **Controlled motivation (“I have to”)** = external coercion + introjection. You feel pressured, by others or by yourself.
- **Autonomous motivation (“I want to”)** = identification + intrinsic. You stand behind what you do; the drive comes from within. *You can be extrinsically **and** autonomously motivated* — that's the crucial move: meaningfulness is “just as good as” intrinsic motivation.

MEANINGFULNESS ≠ INTRINSIC — BUT BOTH ARE AUTONOMOUS

Clearing your desk or backing up your laptop isn't *fun* (not intrinsic), but you do it willingly because it *matters* (identified). Intrinsic focuses on pleasure/interest; identification focuses on value/meaning. Both feel like “I want to.” This is liberating for managers: your job is not to make work an amusement park — it's to make the unpleasant-but-necessary *meaningful*. Recall the two kinds of happiness: **hedonism** (feeling good now — ice cream and Netflix) and **eudaimonia** (living well — realising your potential, which is often hard and frustrating but is where deep satisfaction lives).

“Humans are inherently motivated to grow and achieve and will fully commit to and engage in even uninteresting tasks when their meaning and value is understood.”

— Edward Deci & Richard Ryan

Worked example — five people, five motivations

Person	Reason for the job	Type
Andrew, fishmonger	Rolled into the family business; never asked if he liked it.	Amotivation
Louise, consultant	Chose it for the pay, company car, promotion odds.	External coercion (controlled)
Paul, PhD chemist	Out to prove wrong the teachers who doubted him.	Introjection (controlled)
Dora, care teacher	Helping children with extra exercises feels important.	Identification (autonomous)
Tom, truck driver	Loves hours on the open road.	Intrinsic (autonomous)

Different motivations, different consequences

A meta-analysis of 100+ SDT workplace studies (a meta-analysis pools all research to date, giving highly reliable averages) found the types of motivation predict up to **40% of the variation in how employees feel** and **25–30% of differences in performance** — engagement, job satisfaction, in-role performance, and extra-role behaviour (going beyond the job description).

What each quality of motivation predicts

Motivation	Consequences
Intrinsic	The strongest predictor ($\approx$ half the total effect). Less stress/burnout, more satisfaction & enthusiasm, stronger commitment, no intent to leave, better performance, proactive problem-solving, extra-role helping, less deviance (bullying, loafing, theft), and — uniquely — <i>lower absenteeism</i> .
Identification (meaningfulness)	The second most important — and even more important than intrinsic for performance . It's what makes you deliver quality and persevere on the late-night deadline that is anything but fun.
Introjection	Two faces: raises short-term enthusiasm, but also raises stress and does long-term damage. Little effect on performance.
External coercion	Worst. People will perform under pressure, but it's detrimental to well-being and to the organisation's long-term success.

SUMMARY

Autonomous “I want” motivation → less stress/burnout, more engagement & commitment, less turnover, more effort, better performance. **Controlled “I must” motivation** → the opposite. The extrinsic/intrinsic distinction matters far less than the controlled/autonomous one.

Motivation profiles: people carry several motivations at once

Reality isn't “either/or” — you might value your work, enjoy parts of it, work harder to dodge guilt, *and* like the paycheck, all at once. Scoring people on *autonomous* and *controlled* motivation yields four profiles:

	LOW CONTROLLED	HIGH CONTROLLED
HIGH AUTONOMOUS	Wanters (autonomous) “I want to.” The ideal profile. Low burnout risk (~7%), best work capacity, health, energy, satisfaction. Just keep the environment right.	Highly motivated Want to <i>and</i> have to. Also low burnout & high enthusiasm — but carrying needless control. Remove the control elements to move them toward pure “wanters.”
LOW AUTONOMOUS	Unmotivated Neither. Low well-being & performance. The trick is to grow autonomous motivation — the carrot/stick is tempting but costly.	Musters (controlled) “I have to.” The hardest group: exhausted, little enthusiasm, ~49% burnout risk, double the long-term absence. Don't just strip control — first <i>build</i> autonomous motivation.

Ask managers which they'd want and most say “the highly motivated — more is better.” But the **wanters** do just as well on burnout and enthusiasm *without* the downsides of control. Grant et al. found personal initiative only pays off (more job offers, higher earnings for call-centre staff) for those high in autonomous and low in controlled motivation. Securex data: wanters want to work **four years longer** than musters — this matters for society, not just the firm.

THE COUNTER-INTUITIVE MANAGEMENT RULE

For musters, don't start by *removing* pressure — first **increase autonomous motivation** (make the work meaningful), *then* in a second phase remove the control. Increasing controlled motivation almost never helps and often actively harms.

Motivation is task-specific — beware the “oil slick”

You're not motivated the same way for every task. Teachers may be intrinsically motivated to teach but not to prepare lessons or do admin. Two asymmetries matter:

- **Autonomous motivation is specific and precious** — it attaches to core tasks (teaching, welding, selling, coding) and being autonomously motivated *for the core* is the top predictor of job satisfaction and burnout.
- **Controlled motivation spreads like an oil slick** — once you “have to” do one task, that pressured feeling tends to bleed into the others. So stock the job with enough autonomously-motivating tasks to keep the slick small.

The stakes are real: people say they'll do a task (be on time, write the report) but, if not properly motivated *for that task*, do it poorly or not at all. Only autonomously-motivated students actually enrolled in a training they'd signed up for; only autonomously-motivated employees genuinely share useful knowledge — the pressured ones more often withhold it and pretend not to know.

3. The ABC of motivation: three basic needs

Autonomous motivation doesn't appear by wishing for it. It grows when three **basic psychological needs** are satisfied. Just as the body needs food, water and shelter, the psyche needs Autonomy, Belongingness and Competence to function well. Fulfil the ABC and people are better — not necessarily *more* — motivated.

Autonomy

A

Standing behind what you do — psychological freedom, not doing things against your will.

- Allowed to be yourself
- Experience choice & volition
- Can voice ideas & input
- Initiate your own actions

Belongingness

B

Warm, authentic bonds — feeling liked and cared for, and caring for others.

- Close, trusting relationships
- Genuinely care for others
- Feel accepted, part of a group
- Have someone to turn to

Competence

C

Feeling effective — able to achieve what you set out to do and to grow.

- Feel capable & effective
- Reach desired goals
- Develop skills, master tasks
- Grow — even by making mistakes

Autonomy is the subtle one — and it is *not* independence

Within SDT, autonomy is **not** “deciding everything yourself” (that's independence). It's feeling *psychologically free* — able to stand behind what you do. If the car is heading where you want it to go, the passenger seat can be as good as the driver's seat. You may not choose your clients or patients, yet still go to them willingly because the work speaks to you. Frustrated autonomy feels like a “chain of obligations,” doing things against your will.

Because autonomy $\neq$ independence, the two vary separately — giving four situations:

	INDEPENDENT OF OTHERS	DEPENDENT ON OTHERS
AUTONOMOUS	Independent & autonomous Choose what & how, and fully back it. E.g. the gardener who decides whether to trim hedges or prune trees first.	Dependent but autonomous Rely on others / didn't pick the task, yet fully support it. E.g. a prevention advisor who can't choose the calls but helps very willingly.
NON-AUTONOMOUS	Independent, non-autonomous On your own but <i>not</i> satisfied — e.g. so many choices, or so little structure, you don't know where to start (a cleaner with no brief in an empty house).	Dependent & non-autonomous Forced by circumstances into things you'd rather not do — e.g. assembly-line workers paced by a belt they can't control.

PITFALL · “MORE AUTONOMY = MORE FREEDOM = BETTER” IS WRONG

You cannot give too much *psychological* freedom, but you can easily give too much *actual* freedom/independence. Total freedom often breeds “being left all alone” or chaos — think of people who flounder with unstructured work-from-home. The art is **autonomy with structure**: enough guidelines and support that people can then act autonomously within them. Children may choose mint or strawberry toothpaste — but they *will* brush their teeth.

Belongingness & Competence — briefly

Belongingness is satisfied by warm, trusting bonds where you can share ups *and* downs — not one-off team-building exercises. Harlow's monkeys clung to the soft cloth “mother” over the wire one with the milk; the quality (not quantity) of relationships is a top predictor of happiness. *“It is especially in the sharing of difficulty that we become very close.” — Dirk De Wachter.*

Competence is satisfied when you feel effective, can reach your goals, and can develop your talents — including learning through mistakes. Frustrated competence looks like chronic self-doubt, fear of failure and feeling a disappointment.

Seven characteristics of the ABC needs

1 • Psychological	About mental functioning, not physical needs (food, sleep) — though those matter too.
2 • Essential	Fulfilling them boosts well-being & performance; frustrating them breeds problems.
3 • Not necessarily explicit	You needn't consciously want them — even people who say they don't care about workplace bonds flourish once they feel they belong.
4 • Innate	Part of human nature; even small children feel better when they're met.
5 • Universal	Everyone has all three — labourer or clerk, young or old, introvert or extrovert; they drive growth in everyone.
6 • Fulfilled differently by each	One team handles more autonomy than another; an introvert needs one good talk, an extrovert a busy reception. However filled, a met need = optimal functioning.
7 • Equally important	Unlike Maslow's pyramid, no need must come “first.” They interlink (feeling connected makes autonomy easier), but one can be met while another isn't — and a gap in any one lowers motivation.

Consequences of fulfilling vs. frustrating the ABC

Meta-analytic evidence

ABC fulfilled →	ABC frustrated →
More autonomous motivation	More controlled motivation
Optimal functioning: less stress/burnout, more enthusiasm, commitment, better & more creative performance, extra-role behaviour, persistence, less absence, fewer problem behaviours, even less alcohol/drug use	Work stress; counterproductive behaviour including bullying and aggression
A better, healthier, more vital life <i>outside</i> work too — more energy, more positive & fewer negative emotions, greater life satisfaction	Lower well-being; the positive effects reverse

These effects hold across the West, China and Latin America. Older workers whose needs are met plan less early retirement; even long-term-ill workers volunteering on care farms become readier to return to work when they feel autonomous, belonging and competent. The obvious next question — *how* do you make people feel this way? — is Part 2.

4. Putting it to work: motivating leadership

Leaders are effective not because of who they *are* but because of what they *do*. So which leader behaviours actually satisfy the ABC and grow autonomous motivation?

Four classic leadership styles

Style	In short
Passive	Acts only when problems are out of control; postpones decisions, ignores problems, gives little direction — can be absent altogether.
Task-oriented	Focus on the tasks: provides structure, divides roles, sets goals, defines quality, ties reward to output.
Relationship-oriented	Prioritises people: attentive to emotions, concerned, open to input, friendly, respectful, accessible.
Change-oriented	Leads through change: creates a shared vision, guides through turbulence, encourages innovation and (daring to) take risks.

Research: **relationship-** and **change-oriented** leaders best fulfil employees' ABC and boost autonomous motivation. SDT combines these two into its own style.

ABC-supportive leadership

ABC-supportive (a.k.a. autonomy-supportive) leadership blends the relationship and change approaches and responds directly to the three needs. It works whether it comes from a team lead or the CEO, and across collectivist and individualist cultures alike.

Supports Autonomy

- Offers choices
- Listens to input
- Encourages initiative
- Avoids reward/punishment steering
- Gives a *meaningful rationale* when choice isn't possible

Supports Belongingness

- Shows genuine interest
- Respects & accepts people as they are
- Takes needs & emotions into account
- Empathises; doesn't judge
- Listens empathetically

Supports Competence

- Builds self-confidence
- Helps people grow
- Relies on their abilities
- Focuses on strengths
- Treats mistakes as learning

It is the opposite of controlling leadership

Controlling leaders frustrate the ABC and pump up controlled motivation: micromanaging every step (frustrates autonomy), keeping their distance (frustrates belongingness), pointing out mistakes and doubting ability (frustrates competence), steering by rewards/punishments (external coercion) and using blame and shame (internal coercion). People obey — but half-heartedly, and the stress makes them burnout-prone. They start from Theory X.

But ABC-support is *not* soft — it provides structure

SUPPORT + STRUCTURE

ABC-supportive leadership is not laissez-faire. The best leaders **combine ABC-support with structure**: structure tasks, set clear expectations, follow up on performance, and give clear encouraging feedback. Too little structure = chaos; too much = controlling. Structure feeds the need for *competence*.

Two pitfalls managers fall into

Pitfall	Why it's wrong
1 • “I must check, or nothing happens.”	Pure Theory X. Assuming laziness → you control → you destroy autonomous motivation.
2 • “I daren't follow up — I'll seem controlling.”	Checking ≠ following up. <i>Not</i> following up signals “your work doesn't matter,” frustrating belongingness & competence. Following up shows interest and presence.

Can leaders learn it? Yes.

Intervention studies show ABC-supportive leadership is **trainable**. Deci, Connell & Ryan (1989): during a downturn, an ailing firm trained managers top-to-bottom to let employees take initiative, make choices, receive constructive (not controlling) feedback, and to really listen to needs and emotions. Managers grew in ABC-support; employees' trust in the organisation rose — even in senior managers they barely met. In a residential psychiatric hospital, ABC workshops lifted staff's autonomous motivation and well-being *and* made them less controlling, so the young patients' needs were better met and *their* motivation for treatment rose. *Tips: be patient (people need time to trust the change); and actually use the input you ask for.*

Three preconditions

Trust “The more you trust, the less you need to control.” Trust = **competence** (can do it) + **loyalty** (has your/the org’s interests at heart) + **integrity** (honest, consistent). Not blind trust — a fair chance, then adjust if needed.

Psychological safety A climate where you can speak up without losing face or being seen as incompetent. Successful teams don’t make more mistakes — they *talk* about them. (Steve Jobs on a \$400k error: “We just invested \$400k in a learning experience — I want to hear about it.”) Without safety you can’t let go, trust or learn.

Organisational climate ABC-support works best when the whole climate backs it — valuing free will, cooperation, and growth; avoiding pressure, reward-focus, rivalry, skill-comparison and a single-minded outcome focus. Job insecurity shrinks the benefit of even good leaders.

The ABC language: how you say it

Communication — spoken, emailed, even chat — either invites or coerces. SDT (echoing Rosenberg’s Nonviolent Communication) favours **inviting, connecting language** built from your own needs, and warns against controlling language built from judgements and demands.

Two ways to say things

Inviting / connecting ✓	Coercive / controlling ✗
Open questions: “Could you...”, “What do you need?”	Commands: “Finish this now!”; must-statements: “You must...”
Choice: “You can consider...”; open verbs: “I suggest... do you like that?”	“Because I say so”; “Can you finally do it the way I expect?”
Encourage: “I trust you in this”; invite: “I invite you to try...”	Conditional feedback: “Good — just what I expected of you.”
Informational tips; consultation: “Which deadline is feasible for you?”	Self-esteem hooks: “Someone with your profile should manage this”; guilt & shame: “We’re deeply disappointed...”, “Aren’t you ashamed?”

Request, don’t demand. Demands raise pressure; requests give others the chance to help you — and helping fulfils *their* ABC (they choose to, feel connected, feel competent). Start from your own need (“I feel unsure about the restructuring — can you give me more clarity?”) rather than a reproach (“You never communicate, so I feel bad”). And stay open to “no”: every no is a yes to something else — treat resistance as *information*, not disobedience.

“Every criticism, judgment, diagnosis, and expression of anger is the tragic expression of an unmet need.”

— Marshall B. Rosenberg

ABC-support in hard times: change & working from home

To SDT it doesn't matter *where* people work — autonomous motivation depends on the ABC being met, not on location. Remote work simply makes each need harder to tend:

- **Autonomy** — let people choose hours and task order, but keep enough structure (monitor performance, safeguard quality) to avoid chaos.
- **Belongingness** — the hardest at a distance; isolation breeds loneliness. Invest in real connection: regular one-to-ones (call, video) and a group-level online community — balanced against individual autonomy.
- **Competence** — check everyone can handle the tasks, has the right equipment and space, and knows who to contact when stuck.

PRACTICAL ABC LEADERSHIP TIPS

Autonomy: avoid pressure and micromanagement (even remotely) but *do* follow up; design meaningful, varied, challenging tasks; let people decide and participate; find where resistance comes from.

Belongingness: be empathetic; listen openly; explore needs and concerns; don't judge or accuse; make time to talk even remotely; watch for loneliness (a daily check-in call).

Competence: help set realistic goals; give accurate feedback; avoid competition; judge each person on their own progress, creativity and effort; give time and space to develop; agree how feedback is best delivered at a distance.

5. Glossary & self-test

Key terms

Self-Determination Theory (SDT)	Deci & Ryan's broad, well-tested theory of motivation: quality of motivation depends on satisfying the basic needs for autonomy, belongingness and competence.
Amotivation	Absence of motivation; a sense that acting is futile.
Intrinsic motivation	Doing something for its own sake — because it's interesting or enjoyable.
Extrinsic motivation	Doing something for an outcome beyond the task itself. Comes in three types (below).
External coercion	Extrinsic + controlled: acting under pressure from others (reward/punishment).
Introjection	Extrinsic + controlled: internal pressure — guilt, shame, ego, proving yourself.
Identification (meaningfulness)	Extrinsic but <i>autonomous</i> : acting because the task is valuable/important to you.
Controlled motivation	“I have to” — external + introjected. Pressured; low quality.
Autonomous motivation	“I want to” — identified + intrinsic. Volitional; high quality.
Crowding-out effect	An external reward undermining pre-existing intrinsic motivation (Deci, 1971).
The ABC	The three basic psychological needs: Autonomy, Belongingness, Competence.
Autonomy vs. independence	Autonomy = standing behind what you do (psychological freedom); independence = not relying on others. They vary separately.
Theory X / Theory Y	Pessimistic vs. optimistic views of people (McGregor); SDT starts from Theory Y.
Hedonism / Eudaimonia	Feeling good now vs. living well by realising your potential.
ABC-supportive leadership	Leadership that satisfies the three needs, combining support with structure — the opposite of controlling leadership.
Psychological safety	A climate where people can speak up and admit mistakes without losing face.

Test yourself

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

- Why does SDT argue that “more motivation” is not the goal? What *is* the goal?
- Explain the crowding-out effect using the 1971 puzzle experiment. Why is it a problem for bonus schemes?
- Place the four motivation types on the continuum and mark the controlled/autonomous divide. Which extrinsic type is autonomous, and why?
- Meaningfulness (identification) is extrinsic — so why is it “just as good as” intrinsic motivation?
- Sort the four motivation profiles (wanters, highly motivated, musters, unmotivated) by well-being. Why treat musters by *adding* autonomy before removing control?
- Why is autonomy *not* the same as independence? Give an example of “dependent but autonomous.”
- Give the ABC and one way a remote-working leader can support each need.
- How does ABC-supportive leadership differ from both controlling *and* laissez-faire leadership?
- Rewrite a coercive instruction (“Finish this report now, I expect better from you”) in inviting, needs-based language.
- “What you think is what you get.” Explain how a Theory-X belief becomes self-fulfilling.

FIVE THINGS TO REMEMBER

1. **Quality over quantity:** autonomous (“I want”) motivation drives well-being and performance; controlled (“I must”) motivation doesn't.
2. **The real divide is controlled vs. autonomous,** not extrinsic vs. intrinsic — meaningfulness makes even dull work high-quality.
3. **Rewards can backfire** (crowding-out), so you can't simply buy motivation.
4. **The ABC is the engine:** satisfy Autonomy, Belongingness and Competence and autonomous motivation grows by itself.
5. **Leadership is the lever:** combine ABC-support with structure, trust and psychological safety, and speak an inviting rather than controlling language — “create the conditions in which people motivate themselves.”

Structured study guide based on the Chapter 2 material “Self-Determination Theory / Work Motivation” (Behavior, Society & Economy, KU Leuven — Van den Broeck, Van Coillie, Forest & Müller), which itself builds on the work of Edward Deci & Richard Ryan. Diagrams, tables and self-test questions added for study; wording of the source cleaned up and reorganised, with all core concepts retained.